

Third- and Fourth-Degree Perineal Tears

Patient Information · Severe childbirth tears: repair and healing

WARWIKI

During a vaginal birth, the area between the vagina and anus (the perineum) can tear. A **third-degree** tear reaches the anal sphincter muscle. A **fourth-degree** tear goes through it into the lining of the rectum. These are called **OASIS**. They are repaired carefully soon after birth, and with good aftercare most people heal well.

What Happened

The **anal sphincter** is the ring of muscle that holds in gas and stool. A severe tear reaches this muscle. That is why careful repair and follow-up matter: they protect your bowel control over the long term. About 3 in 100 vaginal births have this kind of tear, and it is more common with a first baby. It is not your fault.

The Repair

The tear is repaired soon after birth, usually in an operating room. You get a spinal or epidural (numbing), or general anesthesia. The tissues are sewn back **in layers**: the sphincter muscle and, for a fourth-degree tear, the lining of the rectum. The stitches dissolve on their own. You get antibiotics, and a plan for pain and bowel care.

Benefits and Risks in Numbers

6–8 in 10

have no bowel symptoms a year after the repair

5–7 in 100

have another severe tear with a later vaginal birth

17 in 100

had worse bowel control after a later vaginal birth, in the studies reviewed

Numbers are averages from published studies. Your own risk may differ; ask your team.

Learn the Terms

Perineum

The area between the vagina and the anus.

OASIS

Obstetric anal sphincter injury. This means a third- or fourth-degree tear.

Anal sphincter

The ring of muscle that controls gas and stool.

Third degree

A tear into the anal sphincter muscle.

Fourth degree

A tear through the sphincter into the lining of the rectum.

Stool softener

Medicine that keeps stools soft so you do not strain.

Pelvic floor therapy

Exercises with a therapist to rebuild strength and control.

Will I have lasting problems? Most people heal well. Some have trouble holding in gas or stool. Follow-up and pelvic floor therapy help, and there are good treatments if problems last. Tell your team about any leaking. Do not wait.

First days

Antibiotics, pain medicine and a stool softener. Your bladder emptying is checked.

Weeks 1–2

Soreness eases day by day. Keep stools soft and the area clean.

Weeks 6–12

Checkup on healing, pain and bowel control.

Before your next birth

Talk about the safest way to deliver.

Healing and Self-Care

- 1 Keep stools soft.** Take the stool softener you are given, often for about 10 days. Drink fluids and eat fiber.
- 2 Pain and hygiene.** Use the pain medicine you are given. Rinse with warm water after using the toilet. Keep the area clean and dry.
- 3 Ease back in.** Things should improve week by week. A cushion and ice early on can help.
- 4 Pelvic floor therapy** is recommended after this kind of tear. It can start as early as 2 to 6 weeks after birth.

Future Births

Talk with your team before your next birth. Many people can have another vaginal birth. A planned cesarean may be offered if you have bowel symptoms or your sphincter tests are not normal. It is advised if you later need a second sphincter repair. A cesarean does not remove every future risk.

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, or chills
- Pain that is getting worse, discharge that smells bad, or a wound that seems to open
- Leaking gas or stool**, or no bowel movement for several days

Go to an emergency department if:

- You **cannot urinate** for several hours and your bladder feels full or painful
- Bleeding that soaks a pad in an hour, or large clots
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Do not put anything in the rectum, such as suppositories or enemas, unless your team says so.

Three Things to Remember

- A third- or fourth-degree tear reaches the anal sphincter. It is repaired in layers soon after birth.
- Soft stools, wound care and pelvic floor therapy help you heal. Most people heal well.
- Tell your team about any leaking of gas or stool, even months later. Help is available.